meddling of veteran commanders and the sniping of others to ‘the Mother’, that is, Maham Anaka. It was Maham, wrote Shamsuddin, who represented his cautious march through muddy fields as cowardice. ‘God deliver us!’ – if Shamsuddin had lost the battle, anyone can imagine how vicious the whispers in court would have been. Even the victory’s aftermath was perverse: people who took no part in the battle received rewards ‘tenfold’, but no one bothered to ask about those who did the actual fighting – among them, Shamsuddin reminded Akbar, the ataka’s own twelve-year-old son.

‘Protector of the world,’ Shamsuddin continued, like Mark Antony to the Roman mob, ‘this well-wisher regards [Maham] as a mother, and says no evil of her’ – but he did wish to point out that none of the nobility had left their fiefs to help Akbar’s ‘old servant’ as he battled in the mud and managed, somehow, to win. Now, he had only one small request. Akbar had already given him Bairam’s insignia, from his banner to his robe, would he not give him Bairam’s rank too?

For all Shamsuddin’s self-deprecation, his power – and that of his family – was only increasing. Indeed, Shamsuddin’s brothers and sons – not one of whom was among Humayun’s commanders six years ago – would soon have enough influence to merit their own collective noun: they would be called the *ataka khail*, the clan of the ataka.

As Maham’s coterie and the ataka khail tested their new authority, a third power centre began to emerge. Mirza Sharafuddin – the Timurid relative from Kashgar who had sent that conspiratorial letter to Pir Muhammad – now married Akbar’s sister, Bakshi Banu, and became, therefore, the padishah’s brother-in-law, his dignity ‘enormously exalted’,[112] and his story about to unravel.

As for the padishah himself – for all the drama of the last few months, all the declarations of taking on the mantle of his own rule – he had retreated, once again, behind his veil. When Bairam left for Mecca, Akbar returned to Agra, and put on his old ‘disguise of inattention’.[113]

The fall of Bairam had not, after all, signalled the rise of Akbar; indeed, you could even argue that Akbar only played a supporting role in a coup against his regent, engineered by his nurse. But now, at the end of this turbulent fifth year of his reign, a chain of events was set in motion, a chain in which Akbar’s veil would find itself entangled and finally ripped off.

.The Cleveland Museum of Art: https://www.clevelandart.org/art/2013.292.a